From the High Street to the Ballot Box: The Political Consequences of Local Shop Closures

Justin Robinson, Geoff Evans, Jane Green, Zack Grant

EPOP 2026

Nuffield College, University of Oxford

Introduction

Elite discourse in Britain increasingly focuses on issues of high street renewal/regeneration.

But political science has yet to engage with high street decline as a *political* phenomenon (with the exception of Fetzer et al. 2025; Jennings 2026)

In this paper we address this gap, asking two questions:

1. What explains high street decline in Britain?
2. Does high street decline impact voting preferences?

Theory - I

Globalization/post-industrial transition has produced new regional economic inequalities within Western economies (Iammarino et al. 2019).

The shift from production to knowledge-intensive sectors (e.g. finance) has led to an uneven concentration of high-skilled, highly paid labour - and disposable income - across regions (Autor 2019).

- Which leads to greater spending on locally serving goods (e.g. restaurants, bars, retail) in 'winning' regions (Centre for Cities 2025; Lee & Clarke 2019).
- And the reverse dynamic in 'losing' regions.
- i.e. the regional 'winners' of globalization have thriving high streets; the 'losers' do not.

This matters for politics as the high street is a highly visible manifestation of these inequalities.

- So the performance of local retail will likely have demand-side political consequences.

Theory - II

How do voters translate high street performance into political behaviour? We argue visible signs of high street decline will lead to more negative evaluations of local economic performance.

Econ. performance (beyond the household) is abstract, so we rely on observable indicators to judge it (Bisgaard et al. 2016; Stevenson & Duch 2013).

The (perceived) vitality of the high street is an important heuristic used by voters to evaluate local econ. performance. Why?

- Regular exposure (via frequent visits) facilitates learning (Baybeck and McClurg 2005).
- Shops are a clear and relevant signal e.g. boarded-up shops indicate declining disposable income.

Theory - III

These negative evaluations of local economic performance will influence vote choice. Three potential mechanisms:

- Accountability (Rogers 2014): vacant shops indicate economic mismanagement from the govt (reward-punishment hypothesis)
- Social marginalization (Huijsmans 2023; Jennings 2025; McKay 2019): vacant shops are a signal that one's area is being 'left behind' relative to better-performing areas.
- Nostalgic deprivation (Gest 2018): newly-vacant shops are a reminder of economic decline relative to the past.

These mechanisms likely lead to anti-incumbent voting generally; and radical right voting specifically.

Data

To measure high street/retail and hospitality performance, we use shop vacancies.

We derive measures of shop vacancies with data from the Local Data Company.

- 10-year time series (2015-2025) of geocoded shop openings and closures across Britain ($\sim$1.8m observations).
- We have exact geographic location for shops (long and lat); plus the exact date of new openings and closures.
- We focus on retail and hospitality (restaurants, bars, pubs).

We conduct aggregate-level analysis using this data; and match it with the British Election Study to conduct individual-level analysis.

Aggregate-Level Analysis

We begin by testing the claim that retail and hospitality performance is an expression of post-industrial winner/loser dynamics at the local authority (LA) level. Our model:

$$Y_l = \beta \, \text{KI Share}_l + \mathbf{X}_l + \varepsilon$$

Y_l - The LA-level vacancy rate (vacant properties / total properties)

- Derived from LDC data, measured in 2025.

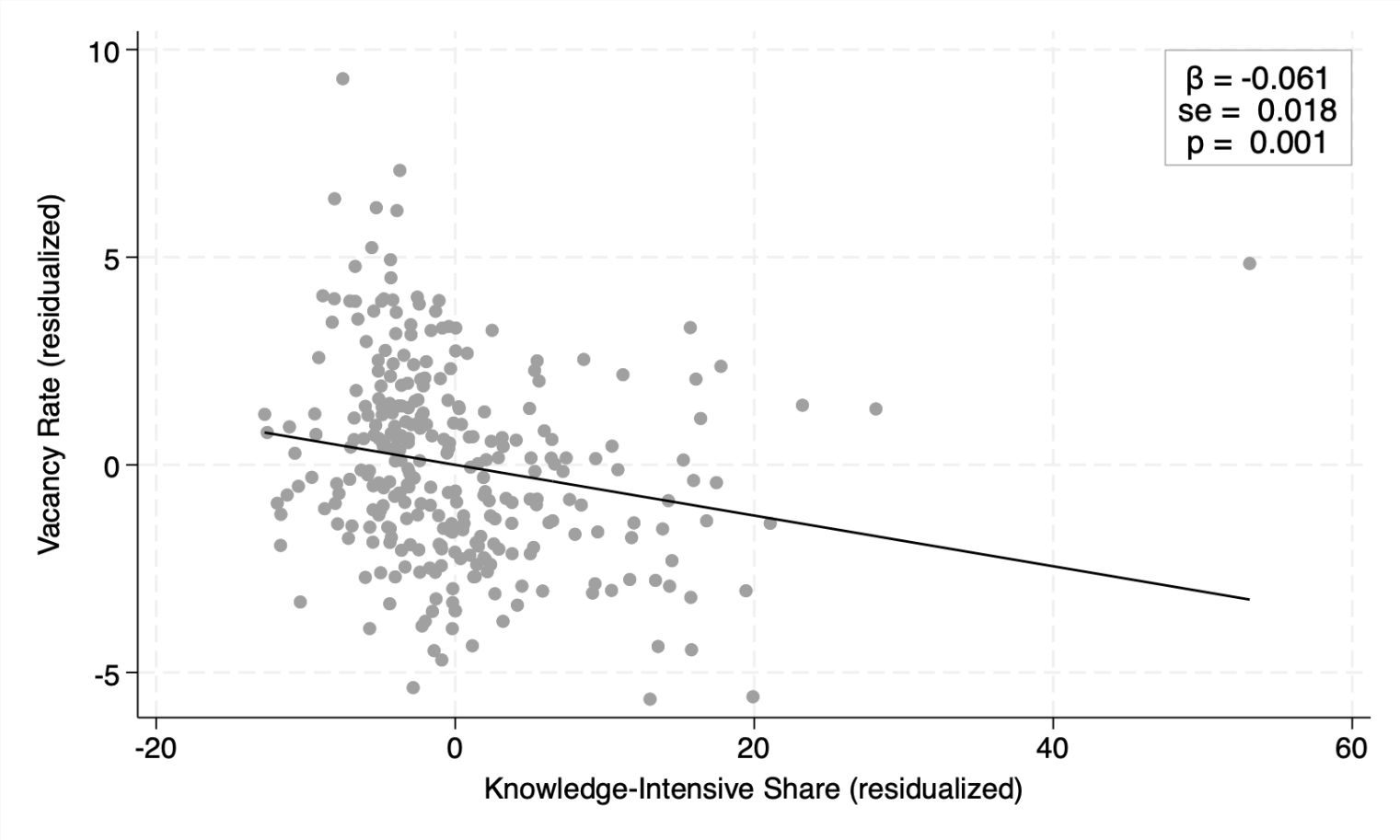
$\beta \, \text{KI Share}_l$ - The share of workers employed in knowledge-intensive sectors: SIC codes J (Information and communication), K (Financial and insurance) and M (Professional, scientific and technical).

- Derived from Business Register and Employment Survey Data, 2024.

Controls ($\mathbf{X}_l$) - international tourist visits; domestic tourism spend; shift-share variable measuring exposure to online shopping.

Results

Figure 1: The Partial Regression of LA Vacancy Rates on Knowledge-Intensive Occupation Shares in England (2025)



Note: Model $N = 296$.

Results - II

Next we test whether the relationship between knowledge-intensive occupation shares and vacancy rates are mediated by average income.

- Our income measure is average (median) annual pay (measured at the LA level), from the Annual Survey of Hours and Earnings, 2025.

We fit a cross-sectional SEM with percentile bootstrap CIs (5000 repetitions).

- We find an indirect effect via average income.
- 89% of the association between the knowledge-intensive occupation share and vacancy rate is mediated by average income.

Evidence indicates regional economic success in the post-industrial transition influences retail and hospitality outcomes, consistent with the high street as a signal of being 'left behind'.

Individual-Level Analysis

Now, we turn to our second RQ: does local retail and hospitality performance influence vote choice?

We match the LDC data with individual-level panel data from the BESIP (W1-W30) using MSOA codes. We examine two DVs:

- Anti-incumbent voting (focusing on the period of Conservative govt. from W1-W29).
- Radical-right voting (for UKIP, Brexit Party or Reform).

We use the LDC data to derive time-varying measures of retail and hospitality performance at the local level, again focusing on vacancies.

- Our key measure is net new vacancies (at BES wave t)
- N new vacancies - N new openings (since the previous wave).

SLX Models - I

We estimate spatial lag of X models (Elhorst et al. 2017).

We model the effect of (net) new vacancies within the respondent's own MSOA (at wave t); and vacancies within neighbouring MSOAs (assuming spatial spillovers).

- The latter effect is modelled with a spatial weights matrix $\mathbf{W}$, modelling the degree of interconnectedness between MSOAs.

$$Y_{it} = \beta\,\text{Vacancies}_{j(i)t} + \beta\mathbf{W}\,\text{Vacancies}_{j(i)t} + \mathbf{X}_{ijt} + \beta\,\text{Immigrant}_{l(i)t} + \lambda_{kt} + \mu_i + \varepsilon_{ij}$$

We regress vote choice at wave t on the MSOA and spatially lagged measures of new vacancies, plus:

- Individual and region-by-wave fixed effects
- Time-varying controls: sociodemographics, n of shops in the respondent's MSOA and spatially lagged MSOAs, and the local authority-level immigrant share.
- SEs clustered by individual and MSOA.

SLX Models - II

For MSOA i, the weight attached to shop closures in MSOA j is defined using a negative exponential function:

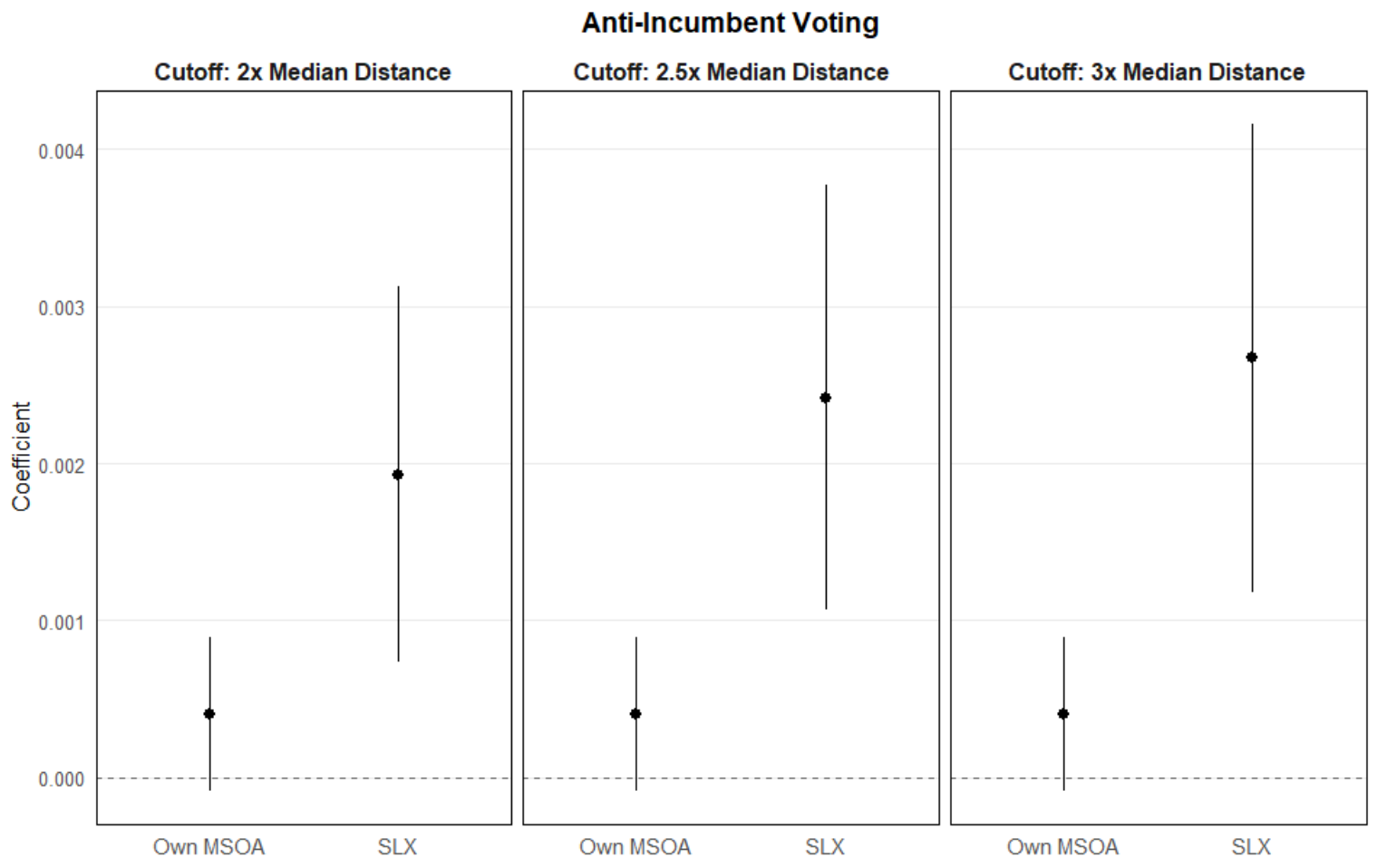
$$w_{kj} = \begin{cases} e^{-\beta d_{kj}}, & d_{kj} < \delta, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Vacancies in more proximate MSOAs are given larger weights - proximity is assumed to increase the likelihood of exposure to vacant shops.

- Weights $= 0$ for all MSOA pairs where $d >$ cutoff parameter.
- β and δ vary between urban and rural MSOAs - as rural residents travel further for shopping in Britain (NTS 2025), weights decline more slowly and encompass a greater range of MSOAs for rural residents.

Results - Anti-Incumbent Voting

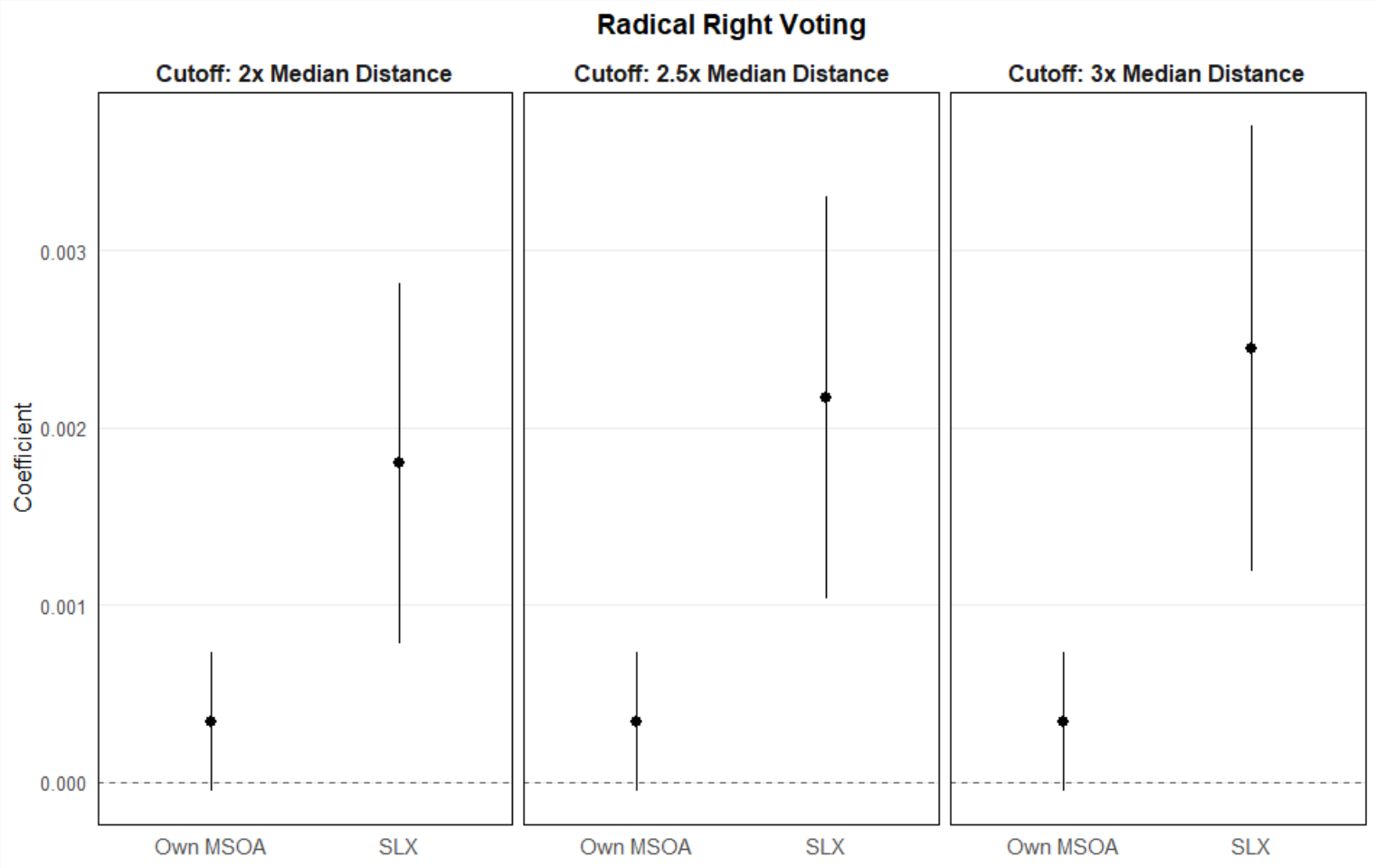
Figure 2: The Regression of Anti-Incumbent Voting on Shop Vacancies (SLX)



Note: Points indicate standardized coefficient estimates and bars denote 95% CIs. Model $N = 389{,}274$.

Results - Radical Right Voting

Figure 3: The Regression of Radical Right Voting on Shop Vacancies (SLX)



Note: Points indicate standardized coefficient estimates and bars denote 95% CIs. Model $N = 403{,}270$.

Further analysis

Effect size: a 1 SD increase in $\mathbf{W}X$ leads to a 0.2pp increase in the probability of voting for the radical right.

People recognise shop vacancies:

- Objective changes in shop numbers (MSOA level) are associated with subjective perceptions ("Thinking about your local or nearest high street, how has the number of shops changed over the past 12 months?").

We also find support for mechanisms. People who live in MSOAs with a higher share of vacant shops are:

- More likely to evaluate local economic performance as negative.
- More likely to believe the national gov. doesn't care about their area.

Robustness Tests

We conduct several robustness tests:

- Results are robust to alternative decay parameter values (0.5x, 1.5x and 2x the median travel distance).
- And to using LA-level change as the explanatory variable, rather than the MSOA SLX measures.
- It is not simply a pocketbook effect - results hold when we exclude individuals who work in retail and hospitality (using Soc2010 codes).

And strengthening our claims of causal identification:

- Results are robust to using local authority-by-wave fixed effects (meaning identification comes from within-LA comparisons).
- Placebo test: no evidence of $(t+1)$ lead effects of vacancies (evidence against pre-trends).

Discussion

The high street appears to be a manifestation of post-industrial winner/loser dynamics.

- Local authorities with a higher share of workers employed in knowledge-intensive occupations have lower vacancy rates.

And the performance of the high-street has consequences for voting behaviour.

- Individual-level analysis shows that new vacancies have a positive effect on the probability of voting for the radical right.

Taken together, our evidence indicates that the high street is another site in which grievance-based politics can play out.

Thank you!

justin.robinson@nuffield.ox.ac.uk

justinrobinson-polsci.github.io